



RBIHF Development structure

2026-2027

Development committee

Introduction

Belgian ice hockey needs a clear, age-appropriate and long-term youth development pathway. If we want to grow into icehockey and become more competitive internationally, we must start by improving the way young players are developed inside our clubs.

At this moment, Belgian ice hockey relies on motivated clubs, committed volunteers and passionate coaches. However, the development structure is not always consistent from club to club. Some clubs have a clear vision and training structure, while others mainly operate in a recreational environment with limited guidance on how to develop players step by step. This creates differences in player development and makes it difficult to build a strong national pathway.

Belgium is a small hockey country, with a limited number of clubs, players and ice rinks. Because of that, every club plays an important role in the future of Belgian ice hockey. We cannot afford to have player development depend only on a few clubs or a few individual coaches. Every Belgian club needs to contribute to the development of better hockey players.

In recent years, we have seen that Belgium is struggling to consistently compete and hold its position on international level. This is not only a national team issue. National team results are the outcome of the development work that happens many years earlier in the clubs. If we want stronger U18, U20 and senior national teams in the future, we need better-developed players entering the pathway at a younger age.

The foundation of player development must therefore be built at U8, U10 and U12 level. These are the most important foundation years. At these ages, the focus should not be on systems, results or early specialization, but on skating, puck skills, movement, confidence, decision-making, fun, creativity and love for the game.

This development plan is created to give Belgian clubs, coaches and national programs a shared direction. It does not replace the work of the clubs. Instead, it provides a common framework that helps every club understand what players should learn at each age, how practices should be organized, and how we can create a stronger connection between club development, Talent Pool and National Team level.

The future of Belgian ice hockey depends on the quality of the foundation we build today.



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Purpose

- Establish a clear, age-appropriate development pathway for youth ice hockey in Belgium;
- provide clubs and coaches with shared development principles and a common coaching direction;
- Define the key skills, habits and learning objectives for each age category;
- Describe how practices should be structured to match the needs of players at each development stage;
- Prevent early over-coaching, tactical overload, early specialization and result-driven development at young ages;
- Strengthen the connection between club development, the Talent Pool program and the Belgian National Teams.

The plan does not replace the work of club coaches. Instead, it provides a shared framework that helps every club develop players in a more consistent and age-appropriate way.

Philosophy

Players must first learn to skate, move, play, think and enjoy the game before they are expected to perform within complex systems.

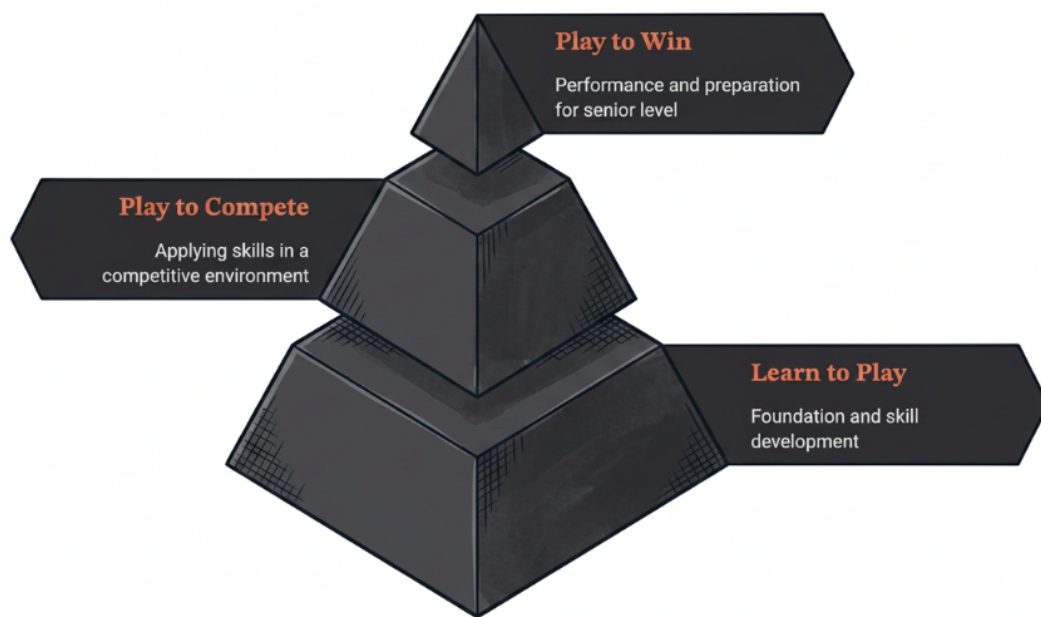
At younger ages, development should focus on fundamental skills, confidence, creativity and enjoyment. Players need many repetitions, many puck touches and many game-like situations. They should be active, involved and challenged in a **positive** environment.





Development Phases

The Belgian Youth Development is built around three progressive development phases: **Learn to Play**, **Play to Compete** and **Play to Win**. These phases describe how the focus of player development should evolve as players grow older and move closer to national team and senior hockey environments.



The model should not be seen as three completely separate blocks. Each phase builds on the previous one. Players cannot successfully compete if they have not first developed a strong technical foundation. In the same way, players cannot be expected to perform in a “Play to Win” environment if they have not learned how to compete with structure, intensity and responsibility.

The largest part of the pyramid is **Learn to Play**, because this is the foundation of development. The U8, U10 and U12 age groups are the most important years for building skating ability, puck skills, confidence, creativity and love for the game. If this foundation is weak, the higher levels of the pathway will also be limited.



The **Play to Compete** phase, covering U14 and U16, introduces more intensity, game understanding and tactical responsibility. Players learn to apply their skills under pressure and within a more competitive environment. Development remains the priority, but players are gradually prepared for higher standards.

The **Play to Win** phase, starting at U18, connects development to performance. At this stage, players should be prepared for senior hockey, national team expectations and international competition. Individual development continues, but team identity, roles, discipline, preparation and results become more important.

This pathway gives Belgian clubs and coaches a shared direction: build the foundation first, teach players how to compete, and only then expect them to perform in a high-performance environment.

Development Phase	Learn to Play	Play to Compete	Play to Win
Age Categories	U8 – U10 – U12	U14 – U16	U18
Main Focus	Foundation and skill development	Applying skills in a more competitive environment	Performance and preparation for senior/national team level
Description	Focuses on technical and physical foundation	Introduces higher intensity and structure	Players understand team identity and systems



Learn to play: U8-U10-U12

General information

Station-Based Practices

Station-based practices should be the preferred practice model in the Learn to Play phase. Instead of having one large group doing the same drill, players are divided into smaller groups and rotate between different stations.

This allows players to receive more repetitions, more puck touches and more individual feedback. It also keeps the practice active and avoids long waiting lines.

A good station-based practice can include 4 to 6 stations, depending on the number of players, coaches and available ice space.

Groups

Groups should ideally contain a **maximum of 5 to 6 players per station**. This keeps the activity level high and allows the coach to give simple, direct feedback.

With 5 or 6 stations, a club can organize an effective practice for 30 to 36 players. At this moment, most Belgian clubs do not have these numbers in one age category, but the structure gives clubs a model that can grow with them.

Coaching Staff and Roles

Every practice should have at least one main coach. The main coach is responsible for the practice plan, the organization of the session and the key development focus of the day.

The ideal practice setup includes:

- 1 main coach responsible for the full practice ;
- The main coach is responsible for station rotation and timing;
- 1 experienced coach who moves between stations and supports the station coaches; This can also be the main coach.
- several station coaches or helpers who manage the exercises.
- support from senior players, junior players, assistant coaches or trained parents where needed.

Not every club will have access to professional coaches or a large coaching staff. In that case, clubs can use parents and volunteers as support staff. However, these helpers must receive clear instructions from the main coach. They do not need to be technical experts, but they must understand the goal of the station, keep players active and help create a safe and positive learning environment.



Timekeeping

Timekeeping is strongly recommended for station-based practices. This person manages the clock, signals when groups rotate and helps the practice stay organized.

This allows the coaches to focus on coaching instead of managing time. It also gives the practice rhythm and prevents stations from running too long or too short.

Small-Area Games

Small-area games should be included in every Learn to Play practice. These games allow players to apply their skills in realistic situations with more puck touches, more decisions and more involvement than full-ice drills.

For U8, U10 and U12 players, small-area games help develop:

- puck protection;
- 1v1 skills;
- support play;
- quick decision-making;
- creativity;
- competitiveness;
- transition between attack and defence.
- Overall skill (skating, puckhandling...)

Small-area games should be used as a development tool, not only as a fun activity at the end of practice.

Avoiding Long Lines and Over-Coaching

Young players learn by doing. Practices should avoid long explanations, long waiting lines and too much correction. So demonstrate drills instead of talking in front of a whiteboard.

Coaches should use short instructions, clear demonstrations and simple coaching points. Players should be allowed to make mistakes, solve problems and learn through repetition.

The goal is not to create perfect players at U8, U10 or U12. The goal is to create confident, skilled and motivated players who are ready for the next stage of development.



Learn To Play: Development Model

1. Main objective

The main objective at U8-U10-U12 is to create a fun, safe and positive first experience with ice hockey. Players should enjoy coming to the rink, feel comfortable on the ice and develop a lasting connection with the sport.

At this age, **enjoyment and player retention are the main measures of success**. Technical development is important, but it should always be delivered through playful, active and age-appropriate activities.

What players must learn

Seasonal Calculation

September through April represents approximately **32 calendar weeks**.

At two hours per week, this provides a theoretical maximum of approximately **64 ice hours**.

Because some clubs have no ice during holiday periods, the practical season will usually contain approximately **50–60 development hours**.

This is the minimal requirements we set for U8's, U10's and U12's this is ofcourse without the games.

LTP players should develop their fundamental skills through games, challenges and playful activities. Because most Belgian clubs have approximately two hours of ice time per week, **skating development must be the main on-ice priority**.

Practice Structure

U8 – U10 or U12 practices should be designed around **fun, movement and maximum participation**. With approximately two hours of ice per week, every minute must be used effectively. Players should spend as little time as possible waiting or listening and as much time as possible skating, playing and touching the puck.

Practice Component	Recommended Time	Main Purpose
Fun skating and movement	35–40%	Balance, agility, starting, stopping and turning
Puck control and basic passing	20–25%	Confidence with the puck
Skill-based games and challenges	15–20%	Applying skills in a playful environment
Small-area games	20–25%	Decision-making, creativity and enjoyment



2. Layout

Example Full Station Practice: 34 Players

For a large group of **34 players**, divide the players into **six groups**:

- four groups of six players;
- two groups of five players.

The full ice is divided into six stations. Each group starts at a different station and rotates in the same direction when the timekeeper gives the signal.

Station	Development Focus
Station 1	Balance and agility
Station 2	Starting and stopping
Station 3	Turning and edge control
Station 4	Puck control
Station 5	Passing or scoring game
Station 6	Small-area game

Players should spend approximately **8 minutes at each station**. Allowing time for short demonstrations and rotations, the station block requires approximately **55–60 minutes**.

Each station should have one coach or instructed helper. One main coach oversees the full practice, keeping time and adjusting where needed.

This format allows a club to organise an active and development-focused practice for 34 players while maintaining groups of no more than six.

Example Practice: 16 Players

Divide the players into three small groups: **two groups of five and one group of six**.

Begin the practice with a **10–15-minute fun warm-up game** involving all players. This creates immediate activity, enjoyment and engagement.

Continue with **three skill stations**. Each group spends approximately **eight minutes at each station**. Including short demonstrations and rotations, this block takes approximately **30 minutes**.



Finish the practice by dividing the players into **two groups of eight** for small-area games. Where possible, organise two games simultaneously to maximise participation, puck touches and decision-making.

Practice Block	Duration	Organisation
Fun warm-up game	10–15 min	All players active
Three skill stations	Approx. 30 min	Groups of 5 and 6
Small-area games	15–20 min	Two groups of 8

Zone	Focus
Station 1	Skating
Station 2	Puck control
Station 3	Agility: obstacle parcour

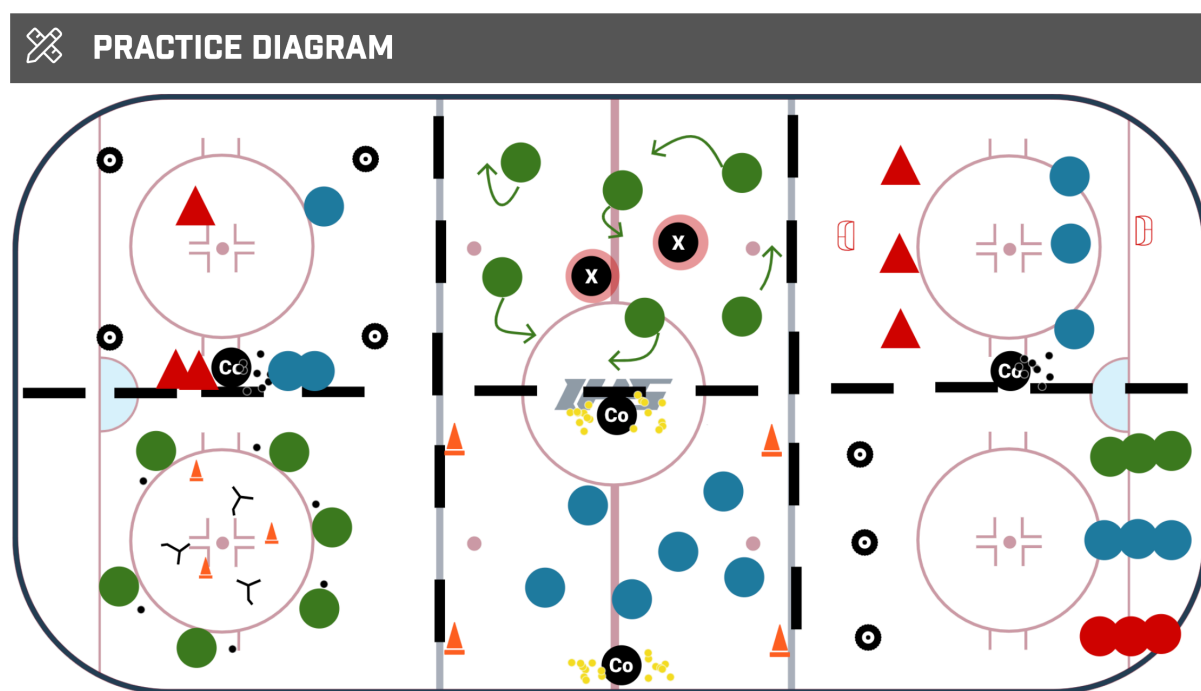
This creates a complete **60-minute U8 practice** based on fun, small groups, skill repetition and learning through play.

Practice examples

Example 1: 6 Stations layout, each station should have its own “support coach”

1 main coach to go around, keep time to make sure the rotation is optimal

each station 5-6 players for optimal moving time

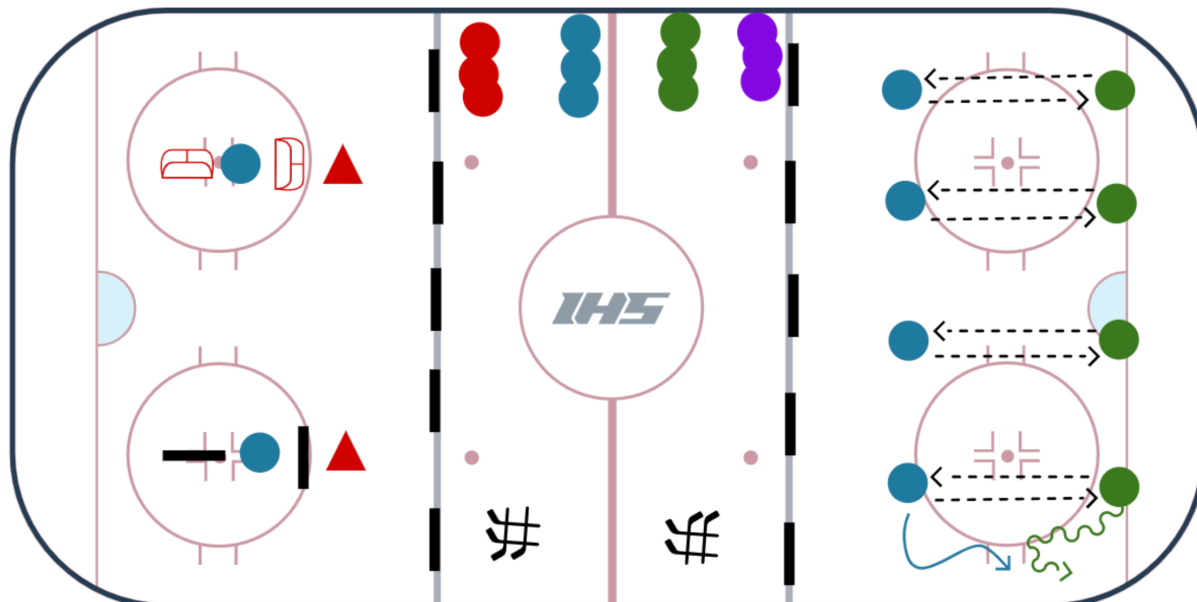


Example Diagram 1



Example 2: 3 station layout example for 3 coaches and 1 main coach each station. 5-6 players for optimal moving time

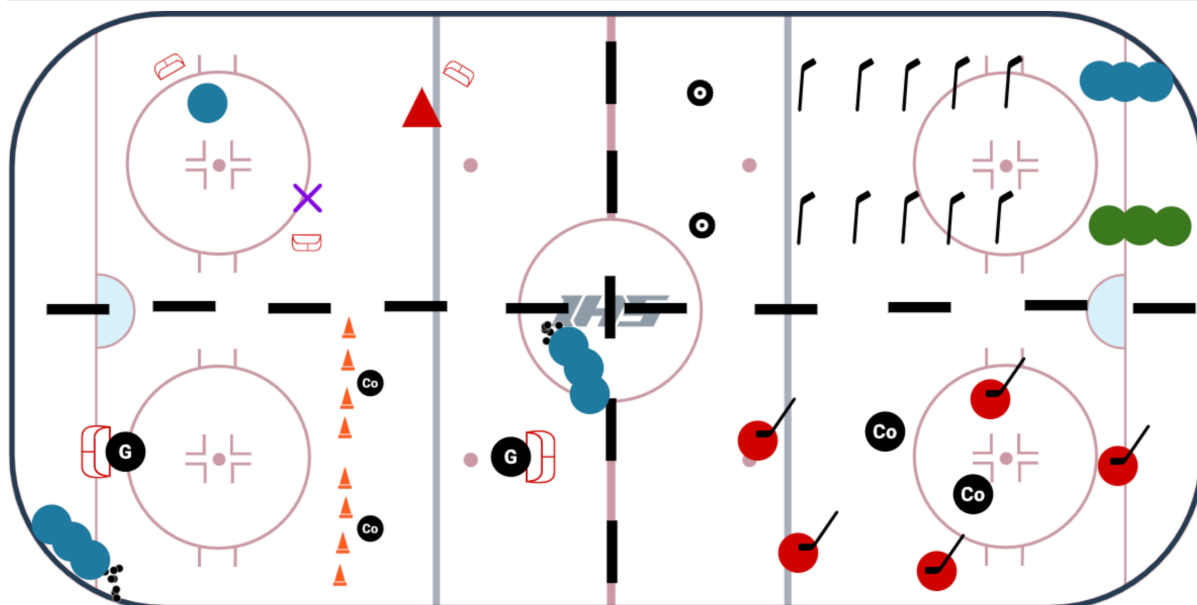
PRACTICE DIAGRAM



Example Diagram 2

Example 3: 4 station layout example for 4 coaches and 1 main coach each station. 5-6 players for optimal moving time
You can add a small area game at the end or fun game to start your practice with

PRACTICE DIAGRAM



Example Diagram 3



3. *LTP Outcomes*

Throughout the Learn to Play phase, players should progressively develop the technical, physical, social and personal foundations needed to continue their hockey journey. By the end of the Learn to Play phase, players should ideally:

Skating and Movement

- move confidently and independently on the ice;
- demonstrate balance, agility and control;
- start, accelerate, stop and change direction effectively;
- skate forward and backward with developing technique;
- use their edges and maintain control during different movements.

Puck Skills

- control the puck on the forehand and backhand;
- carry the puck while moving and changing direction;
- pass and receive while stationary and in motion;
- direct the puck towards the net;
- combine skating and puck skills in game situations.

Game Understanding

- participate actively in small-area and age-appropriate games;
- recognise changes between attack and defence;
- find open space and support the puck carrier;
- attempt to recover the puck when defending;
- make simple decisions under pressure;
- cooperate with teammates;
- experience different roles and positions.

Personal Development

- enjoy attending practices and games;
- feel safe, valued and included;
- listen, learn and attempt new challenges;
- demonstrate respect towards teammates, coaches and opponents;
- develop confidence, creativity and independence;
- **build a lasting love for hockey.**

The most important outcome is a player who enjoys the game and wants to continue playing.
Fun drives retention, and retention creates long-term development.

These outcomes are development targets, not selection criteria. Children develop at different speeds and should not be prevented from progressing because they have not yet mastered every skill. The age-specific skills matrices define the expected technical progression for U8, U10 and U12.



4. What to avoid

Practices and games during the Learn to Play phase should not resemble adult or performance-level hockey. Coaches and clubs should avoid:

- long explanations and complicated coaching language;
- long lines and activities with limited participation;
- full-ice drills involving only a small number of players;
- conditioning without a puck, game or playful purpose;
- excessive tactical instruction and complex systems;
- prioritising systems over individual skill development;
- fixing players into positions too early;
- forcing early goaltender specialisation;
- spending excessive ice time on isolated shooting or stickhandling technique;
- eliminating players from games or activities;
- punishing mistakes or unsuccessful skill attempts;
- using skating, laps or physical exercises as punishment;
- giving stronger players more ice time or attention;
- focusing on scores, standings and tournament results;
- measuring development only through formal testing;
- reducing creativity through constant correction.

At U8 and U10, clubs should use a goaltender rotation system so every interested player can experience the position. At U12, players may begin showing a positional preference, but opportunities should remain flexible

Skill Development Progression





5. Competition targets

Category	Seasonal Competition Target	Game Format
U8	Minimum 15 tournament per season	At least four 15-minute cross-ice mini-games per tournament morning
U10	Minimum 20 tournament per season	At least four 15-minute reduced-ice mini-games per tournament morning
U12	Minimum 30 games per season : Cross / full ice	Cross-ice competition until December, followed by full-ice competition from January

U8

U8 players should participate in a minimum of **15 tournaments** between September and April/May. During each tournament, players should play at least four 15-minute cross-ice mini-games against teams from different clubs.

Fifteen tournament mornings across an eight-month season represents approximately one event every two weeks. This creates regular game exposure without allowing competition to replace practice and skill development.

U10

U10 players should participate in a minimum of **20 tournaments** during the season. Each event should provide at least four 15-minute cross-ice mini-games.

The higher number of events gives U10 players more opportunities to apply their developing skating, puck skills and decision-making in game situations.

U12

U12 players should participate in a minimum of **30 games** during the season:

- **September-December:** cross-ice competition;
- **January-April/May:** progression to full-ice competition.

The cross-ice period maximises puck touches, involvement and decision-making. Full-ice competition is introduced during the second half of the season so players can gradually learn spacing, positioning and basic team principles.



6. Game philosophy

Games are an important part of player development. They allow children to apply their skills, make decisions, compete and experience the enjoyment of playing hockey. During the Learn to Play phase, games should support development rather than focus primarily on results.

Meaningful playing time

Every player should receive meaningful and approximately equal playing time. Participation should not depend on current ability, physical maturity or the score of the game.

All players need opportunities to:

- play in different situations;
- handle the puck;
- make decisions;
- experience success and failure;
- contribute to their team.

No shortening the bench

Coaches should not reduce the number of players being used to win a game. Every selected player should remain involved throughout the event.

Players must not lose playing time because they make mistakes. Mistakes are a necessary part of development and should be used as learning opportunities.

Position rotation

U8 and U10 players should rotate through all skater positions. Clubs should also provide interested players with opportunities to experience goaltending. RBIHF can help with interchangeable goalie gear!

At U12, players may begin to develop positional preferences. However, continued rotation is encouraged to develop broader game understanding and prevent premature specialisation.

Development before results

Coaching decisions should be based on long-term player development rather than short-term results. The quality of play, individual improvement, effort, creativity and decision-making are more important than the final score.



U8 - Skills

Characteristic	Description
Season	September-April/May
Available Ice Time(practice)	Approximately 2 hours per week
Practice Focus	Fun, skating development, balance, movement skills, basic puck confidence and small-area games
Game Format	tournament format involving several clubs, with minimum four 15-minute cross-ice games per event
Minimum Games	Minimum 15 “tournaments” per player per season

U8 Skills Matrix

Development Area	Core Skills	Expected Outcome	Priority
Balance and Agility	- Basic hockey stance - Falling and getting up - Independently - Two-foot and one-foot balance - Two-foot and one-foot gliding - Jumping and controlled landing - Stepping and moving around obstacles	Moves confidently and independently on the ice	High
Edge Control	- Basic inside-edge use - Simple forward figure-eights - Slalom movements - Leaning and changing direction	Uses the edges to turn and control movement	High
Starting and Acceleration	- T-start - Front V-start - Basic acceleration through games and races	Starts independently and gains forward momentum	High
Stopping	- One-foot stop - Introduction to the two-foot parallel stop on both sides	Slows down and stops safely with basic control	High
Forward Skating	- C-cuts with both feet - T-push - Basic forward stride - Knee bend - Basic arm movement	Skates forward with improving balance, rhythm and control	High



Backward Skating	- Basic backward stance - Backward walking - Two-foot backward glide - Introduction to backward C-cuts	Moves backward with basic balance and confidence	Introduction
Turning and Direction Changes	- Glide turns in both directions - Simple tight turns - Stepping around obstacles - Introduction to forward crossovers	Changes direction while maintaining basic balance and control	High
Stationary Puck Control	- Basic hockey stance with the puck - Wide and narrow puck control - Side-to-side puck control - Forehand and backhand puck contact	Controls the puck on both sides of the body while stationary	Medium / off-ice supported
Moving Puck Control	- Pushing the puck forward - Carrying the puck on the forehand and backhand - Moving around obstacles with the puck - Protecting the puck from simple pressure	Carries the puck while skating with basic control	Medium
Passing	- Push pass - Basic forehand sweep pass - Passing through gates - Passing towards a nearby partner or target	Directs the puck towards a nearby teammate or target	Introduction
Receiving	- Presenting the stick as a target - Stopping and controlling an incoming puck - Receiving a pass from a short distance	Receives and controls a simple pass	Introduction
Shooting	- Pushing or sweeping the puck towards the net - Basic forehand sweep-shot movement - Directing the puck towards a target	Understands how to direct the puck towards the net or another target	Exposure / off-ice teaching



U10 - Skills

Characteristic	Description
Season	September-April/May
Available Ice Time (practice)	Approximately 2 hours per week
Practice Focus	Continued skating development, fundamental puck skills, passing, receiving, shooting, decision-making and small-area games
Game Format	tournament format involving several clubs, with minimum four 15-minute cross-ice games per event
Minimum Games	Minimum 20 “tournaments” per player per season

U10 Skills matrix

Development Area	Core Skills	Expected Outcome	Priority
Balance and agility	- Strong basic hockey stance - One-foot balance while moving - Controlled jumping and landing- Lateral movement - Moving around obstacles with and without a puck	Maintains balance and body control during increasingly complex movements	High
Edge control	- Inside and outside-edge control - Forward figure-eights - One-foot edge glides - Slalom movements - Introduction to backward edge control	Uses inside and outside edges confidently to control movement	High
Starting	- Front V-start - T-start - Crossover start - Introduction to backward C-cut start - Short-distance acceleration	Starts quickly in different directions and accelerates with control	High



Stopping	- Two-foot parallel stop on both sides - One-foot stop - Stop and restart - Introduction to backward stopping	Stops confidently on both sides and quickly returns to play	High
Forward skating	- Efficient forward stride - Knee bend and full leg extension - Controlled recovery - Arm movement - Changes of speed	Skates forward with improved power, rhythm and efficiency	High
Backward skating	- Backward stance - Backward C-cuts with both feet- - Alternating backward C-cuts - Basic backward stride - Backward gliding on one and two skates	Skates backward with developing rhythm, balance and control	High
Turning and direction changes	- Tight turns in both directions - Forward crossovers - Introduction to backward crossovers - Forward-to-backward pivots - Backward-to-forward pivots	Changes direction smoothly while maintaining balance and momentum	High
Stationary puck control	- Wide and narrow puck control - Side-to-side and side-front-side control - Forehand and backhand control - Introduction to toe drags - Puck control with the head up	Controls the puck around the body while developing awareness	Medium / off-ice supported



Moving puck control	- Forehand and backhand carry - Open-ice carry - Weaving with the puck - Changing speed and direction - Basic puck protection	Maintains puck control while skating and changing direction	High
Passing	- Forehand sweep pass - Introduction to backhand passing - Passing toward stationary and moving targets - Passing through gates - Pass-and-follow	Delivers controlled and increasingly accurate short passes	Medium
Receiving	- Presenting the stick as a target - Cushioning an incoming puck - Forehand and backhand reception - Receiving while moving - Receiving and continuing the play	Receives and controls passes while stationary and in motion	Medium
Shooting	- Forehand sweep shot - Wrist-shot foundation - Backhand sweep shot - Shooting while moving	Shoots with developing technique, accuracy and power	Medium / off-ice supported
Game understanding	- Finding open space - Supporting the puck carrier - Choosing between passing, carrying and shooting - Transitioning between attack and defence	Makes simple decisions with and without the puck	High
Behaviour and enjoyment	- Effort and positive competition - Teamwork and communication - Respect for others - Trying different positions - Accepting mistakes and feedback - Continued enjoyment	Participates confidently, supports teammates and remains motivated	Essential



U12 - Skills

Characteristic	Description
Season	September-April/May
Available Ice Time	Approximately 2 hours per week
Practice Focus	Applying skating and puck skills at speed and under pressure, individual tactics, passing in motion, puck support, decision-making and basic team principles
Game Format	Structured cross ice games and full-ice games, with equal participation and no fix positions
Minimum Games	Minimum 25 games per player per season (cross and full)

U12 Skills matrix

Development Area	Core Skills	Expected Outcome	Priority
Balance and agility	- Dynamic hockey stance - One-foot balance at speed - Controlled jumping and landing - Lateral movement and recovery - Combining movements around obstacles	Maintains balance and body control while moving at speed and under pressure	High
Edge control	- Inside and outside edges on both feet - Forward and backward figure-eights - One-foot edge control - Edge transitions - Changes of speed and direction	Uses both edges effectively to accelerate, turn, escape and protect the puck	High
Starting	- Explosive V-start - T-start - Crossover start - Backward C-cut start - Starts in reaction to visual or game cues	Accelerates quickly in different directions and reacts effectively to changing situations	High



Stopping	- Two-foot parallel stops on both sides - One-foot stops - Backward stops - Stop-and-start movements- Stops while controlling the puck	Stops and restarts quickly while maintaining balance and readiness	High
Forward skating	- Efficient stride with full extension and recovery - Acceleration and speed changes - Crossovers for speed - Skating with the head up - Skating under pressure	Skates efficiently at different speeds while maintaining awareness and control	High
Backward skating	- Efficient backward C-cuts - Backward stride - Backward crossovers- Acceleration backward - Maintaining an appropriate defensive gap	Skates backward confidently and uses backward movement effectively when defending	High
Turning and transitions	- Tight turns at speed - Forward and backward crossovers - Forward-to-backward pivots - Backward-to-forward pivots - Open and reverse pivots - Escape turns	Changes direction and transitions smoothly without losing significant speed or awareness	High
Stationary puck control	- Wide, narrow and side-front-side control - Forehand and backhand control - Puck movement around the body - Head-up puck control	Controls and manipulates the puck confidently while scanning the environment	Medium / off-ice supported
Moving puck control	- Forehand and backhand carry at speed - Open-ice and close-control carrying - Puck protection - Changes of pace and direction - Escape moves - Puck retrievals	Maintains and protects puck possession while moving at speed and under pressure	High



Passing	- Accurate forehand and backhand passes - Passing while moving - Passing to space - Bank passes - Give-and-go actions - Passing under pressure	Delivers accurate and purposeful passes to stationary and moving teammates	High
Receiving	- Forehand and backhand reception - Receiving while moving - Receiving passes from different angles - Receiving under pressure	Receives and controls the puck without unnecessarily slowing down the play	High
Shooting	- Wrist and sweep shot - Backhand shot - Shooting in motion - Shooting after receiving a pass	Selects and executes an appropriate shot in game situations	Medium / off-ice supported
Individual attack	- Body and stick deception - Change of speed - Puck protection - Net drives- 1v1 offensive play	Creates space and attacks defenders with confidence and purpose	Through drills and games
Individual defence	- Defensive-side positioning - Angling - Stick positioning	Uses positioning, skating and stick control to limit opponents and recover the puck	Through drills and games
Game understanding	- Pass, carry or shoot decisions - Width and depth - Puck support - Creating and using open space	Makes appropriate decisions at speed and contributes with and without the puck	High
Basic team principles	- Basic positional responsibilities - Basic breakout and regroup principles - Forecheck principles - Backchecking through the middle - Defensive-zone positioning - Communication and line change habits	Understands and applies simple team principles without relying on complex systems	Introduction
Behaviour and development	- Consistent effort - Respect and discipline - Coachability - Continued enjoyment	Takes increasing responsibility while remaining motivated to learn and compete	Essential



Play to Compete: U14-U16

General information

The Play to Compete phase includes the U14 and U16 age categories. This phase is the bridge between the Learn to Play foundation and the Play to Win environment at U18.

At this stage, players should already have a basic technical foundation. The focus now shifts toward applying those skills at higher speed, under pressure and within more realistic game situations. Players must learn how to compete, make decisions, support teammates, defend with purpose and understand basic team principles.

Development remains the priority. However, the environment should become more demanding. Players should be challenged to train with intensity, accept feedback, compete consistently and take more responsibility for their own development.

The Play to Compete phase should not become only about winning games. Winning becomes part of the learning environment, but the main goal is to prepare players for the standards required at U18, Talent Pool and National Team level.

Station-Based Practices

Station-based practices can still be used in the Play to Compete phase, but they should no longer be the main practice model all the time.

U14 and U16, stations are useful for:

- individual skill development;
- skating and edge work;
- shooting repetitions;
- puck protection;
- body contact preparation;
- position-specific work;
- small-group tactical situations.

However, players at this age also need more connected drills and game-like situations. Practices should include flow drills, transition drills, 1v1, 2v1, 2v2, 3v2 situations, small-area games and basic team concepts.



Groups

Group size can be slightly larger than in Learn to Play, depending on the drill objective. For technical work, smaller groups are still preferred because they create more repetitions and better feedback.

For tactical and game-like drills, groups may be larger because players must learn timing, spacing, support, transition and role responsibility.

As a general guideline:

Practice Type	Recommended Group Size
Technical station work	5-8 players
Small-area games	6-10 players
Tactical/game-situation drills	8-12 players
Team concept work	Full line or team units

The key principle remains the same: players should be active, involved and challenged. Practices should avoid long waiting lines and drills where only one or two players are active.

General Practice Methodology

U14 and U16 practices should be more game-like and more demanding than Learn to Play practices. While technical skill development remains important, players must now learn to execute skills under pressure, at speed and with tactical purpose.

Practices should include a combination of:

- skating and puck skill maintenance;
- individual tactics;
- 1v1, 2v1, 2v2 and 3v2 situations;
- small-area games with specific objectives;
- flow drills that connect skills to game situations;
- transition drills;
- basic team principles;
- compete drills;
- position-specific learning;
- off-ice physical development.

Station-based practices can still be used, especially for technical work or when large groups are on the ice. However, U14 and U16 players also need more connected drills where they learn timing, spacing, support, pressure, transition and team habits.



Coaching Staff and Roles

Every U14 and U16 practice should have one main coach responsible for the full session. The main coach prepares the practice plan, defines the focus points and ensures that the practice matches the development goals of the age group.

The ideal coaching setup includes:

- one main coach responsible for the full practice;
- assistant coaches responsible for specific drills or player groups;
- position-specific support where possible;
- a goalie coach where available;
- support from senior players or experienced coaches when needed.

At this stage, coaches must give more detailed feedback than in Learn to Play. Players should be corrected on technical details, decision-making, body position, support, defensive habits and tactical understanding.

However, coaching should still be clear and efficient. Long explanations should be avoided. Players learn best when coaching points are short, specific and connected to the drill or game situation.

Timekeeping

Timekeeping remains important, but the structure is different from Learn to Play.

In U14 and U16 practices, time should be managed around practice blocks rather than only station rotations. A typical practice may include:

- warm-up and skating activation;
- technical skill block;
- individual or group tactical block;
- game-situation drills;
- small-area games or compete drills;
- team concept work.

The main coach should control the timing of each block and make sure the practice keeps intensity and rhythm. Drills should not run too long if the quality drops. It is better to have shorter, high-intensity blocks than long drills with declining focus.



Small-Area Games

Small-area games remain important in the Play to Compete phase, but they should now have clearer tactical objectives.

At U14 and U16, small-area games should be used to develop:

- puck protection under pressure;
- support around the puck;
- quick offensive and defensive transition;
- 1v1 compete habits;
- defensive-side positioning;
- communication;
- scanning before receiving the puck;
- decision-making under pressure;
- battle level and compete habits.

Small-area games should not only be used as fun games at the end of practice. They should be planned as development tools with a specific theme, such as support below the puck, quick transition, net-front play, wall battles or defensive positioning.

Avoiding Long Lines and Over-Coaching

U14 and U16 players need more structure than younger players, but practices should still avoid long lines, passive waiting time and excessive talking.

Coaches should avoid:

- drills where players wait too long between repetitions;
- long tactical explanations before players understand the situation;
- stopping drills too often;
- over-coaching every mistake;
- focusing only on systems and removing creativity;
- using conditioning as punishment;
- allowing only the strongest players to receive meaningful feedback;
- turning every practice into a team systems session.

Players at this age need correction, but they also need repetition, challenge and responsibility. Coaches should give clear feedback, allow players to try again and connect corrections to real game situations.

The goal is to create players who can compete with skill, intelligence, discipline and confidence.



U14

Development Area	Core Skills	Expected Outcome	Priority
Skating	Speed development; forward and backward stride efficiency; crossovers; pivots; tight turns; acceleration; stops and starts under pressure	Skates efficiently in game situations and can change direction, speed and body position with control	High
Edge Control and Agility	Inside/outside edge control; escape turns; transitions; lateral movement; evasive skating	Uses edges to escape pressure, defend, attack and maintain balance in traffic	High
Puck Control	Puck protection; open-ice carry; close-control carry; deception; retrievals; puck control under pressure	Maintains puck possession while skating at speed and under pressure	High
Passing and Receiving	Forehand/backhand passing; passing in motion; receiving under pressure; give-and-go; passing to space; support passing	Moves the puck accurately and supports teammates in game-like situations	High
Shooting and Scoring	Wrist shot; snap-shot introduction; backhand shot; shooting in motion; shooting after a pass; rebounds; net drives	Creates scoring chances through improved shot selection, timing and net attack	Medium / High
Individual Attack	1v1 attacks; change of speed; body and stick deception; puck protection; attacking inside and outside lanes	Challenges defenders with confidence and purpose	High
Individual Defence	Angling; gap control; defensive-side positioning; stick positioning; body contact preparation; containment	Defends with better positioning, skating and stick discipline	High
Group Tactics	2v1, 2v2, 3v2; puck support; width and depth; offensive-zone support; defensive support	Understands basic group play and supports teammates with and without the puck	High
Team Principles	Basic breakout; regroup; forecheck principles; backcheck through the middle; defensive-zone positioning; line changes	Understands simple team concepts without relying on complex systems	Introduction / Medium
Physical Development	Coordination; mobility; speed; body control; introduction to strength habits; injury prevention	Develops athletic habits needed for higher training intensity	Medium
Mental and Behavioural Habits	Compete level; coachability; communication; preparation; discipline; respect; accountability	Learns how to train and compete with responsibility	Essential



U16

Development Area	Core Skills	Expected Outcome	Priority
Skating	Explosive acceleration; efficient stride; backward speed; transitions at speed; agility under pressure; skating with contact	Skates with speed, power and control in competitive game situations	High
Edge Control and Mobility	Advanced pivots; escape skating; lateral movement; edge control in battles; quick recovery movements	Uses skating to create separation, defend space and win pressure situations	High
Puck Control	Puck protection under contact; deception; retrievals; wall play; puck control in traffic; quick puck movement	Maintains or moves the puck effectively under pressure and contact	High
Passing and Receiving	Passing under pressure; one-touch passing; passing to space; stretch passes; receiving in motion; support timing	Moves the puck with speed, purpose and awareness	High
Shooting and Scoring	Quick release; shooting through screens; shooting off the pass; rebounds; tips; net-front play; shot selection	Becomes more dangerous in scoring areas and understands how goals are created	High
Individual Attack	1v1 attacks; puck protection; attacking seams; offensive reads; net drives; playmaking under pressure	Creates offensive advantages through skill, timing and decision-making	High
Individual Defence	Gap control; angling; body contact; stick detail; shot blocking basics; defending rushes; wall battles	Defends with structure, physical confidence and tactical awareness	High
Group Tactics	2v1, 2v2, 3v2, 3v3; support layers; transition play; pressure and recovery; offensive and defensive reads	Applies skills within more advanced game situations	High
Team Structure	Breakouts; regrouping; forecheck/backcheck; defensive-zone coverage; neutral-zone habits; offensive-zone principles	Understands and executes basic team structure with consistency	High
Special Teams	Power-play principles; penalty-kill principles; face-off responsibilities; role awareness	Is introduced to special-team roles and simple execution principles	Introduction / Medium
Physical Development	Strength foundation; speed and power; mobility; core stability;	Builds the physical base required for U18 and senior hockey	High



Development Area	Core Skills	Expected Outcome	Priority
Mental and Behavioural Habits	recovery habits; off-ice training discipline Accountability; leadership habits; preparation; resilience; communication; team-first behaviour	Trains with maturity and understands competitive standards	Essential



Play to win: U18

General Information

The Play to Win phase starts at U18. This phase prepares players for senior hockey, national team standards and international competition.

At U18, development continues, but the environment becomes more performance-driven. Players are expected to train with intensity, understand team structure, accept roles, prepare properly and compete to win.

The focus is no longer only on learning basic skills or learning how to compete. Players must now apply their skills within a team identity and a structured game model. Individual development remains important, but it must support team performance.

The Play to Win phase should create players who are technically capable, tactically responsible, physically prepared, mentally disciplined and ready for higher-level hockey.

Station-Based Practices

Station-based practices are no longer the main practice model at U18, but they can still be used for specific purposes.

At U18, stations are useful for:

- position-specific skill development;
- shooting and scoring repetitions;
- face-off work;
- puck protection and battle skills;
- defensive details;
- goaltender-specific situations;
- special teams details;
- individual correction.

Most U18 practices should be built around connected, game-like training. Players need drills that include timing, pressure, reads, support, transition, team structure and execution.

The focus should move from isolated repetition toward applying skills within the team game model.



Groups

Group organisation at U18 depends on the objective of the practice block.

Smaller groups are still useful for technical detail and position-specific work. Larger groups and full-team units are needed for systems, special teams, breakouts, forechecks, defensive-zone coverage and game preparation.

As a general guideline:

Practice Type	Recommended Group Size
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Position-specific skill work	4-8 players
Battle and compete drills	6-10 players
Line or unit work	5-10 players
Team structure drills	Full team or full units
Special teams	PP / PK units

The key principle at U18 is quality and purpose. Every drill should connect to individual improvement, team identity or game performance.

Coaching Staff and Roles

Every U18 practice should have a clear coaching structure. The head coach is responsible for the full practice plan, team identity and performance objectives.

The ideal coaching setup includes:

- one head coach responsible for the full practice;
- assistant coaches responsible for specific units or tactical areas;
- a goalie coach where possible;
- support for video, physical preparation and recovery where available;
- clear communication between club coaches, Talent Pool staff and national team staff.

At this stage, coaches should provide detailed feedback on execution, habits, decision-making, positioning, discipline and role responsibility.

Players should understand not only what they are doing, but why it matters within the team structure.



Timekeeping

Timekeeping at U18 should support intensity, rhythm and game preparation.

Practices should be organised into clear blocks, such as:

- activation and warm-up;
- technical or position-specific work;
- tactical execution;
- transition and game-situation drills;
- special teams;
- compete drills;
- game preparation or review.

Practice blocks should be timed carefully. Drills should be long enough to create learning and repetition, but not so long that intensity, focus or execution quality drops.

At U18, practice tempo matters. Players must learn to train with pace, urgency and attention to detail.

Small-Area Games

Small-area games remain valuable at U18, but they should be used with clear performance objectives.

At this stage, small-area games should develop:

- puck protection under heavy pressure;
- quick transition;
- offensive and defensive reads;
- wall battles;
- net-front battles;
- support below and above the puck;
- communication;
- decision-making under pressure;
- compete level;
- scoring habits;
- defensive responsibility.

Small-area games at U18 should be intense, competitive and connected to the team's playing principles. They are not only a fun element, but a tool to develop habits that transfer directly to games.



Avoiding Long Lines and Over-Coaching

Even at U18, players should not spend excessive time standing in lines or listening to long explanations. The practice must remain active, intense and purposeful.

Coaches should avoid:

- low-tempo drills with limited game relevance;
- long tactical talks on the ice;
- stopping every drill too often;
- overloading players with too many systems at once;
- ignoring individual skill development;
- using conditioning as punishment;
- allowing poor habits because the drill structure is unclear;
- focusing only on results without improving the process;
- unclear player roles;
- inconsistent standards.

At U18, standards must be high, but they must also be clear. Players should know what is expected in practice, games, preparation, discipline and team behaviour.

The goal is to prepare players for environments where performance matters, while still continuing their individual development.



Skills matrix u18

Development Area	Core Skills	Expected Outcome	Priority
Skating	High-speed execution; explosive acceleration; efficient stride under fatigue; transitions under pressure; position-specific skating	Skates at performance level and maintains execution under pressure and fatigue	High
Puck Control	Puck protection under pressure; quick handling; deception; retrievals; wall play; puck management; possession decisions	Makes reliable puck decisions in high-pressure situations	High
Passing and Receiving	One-touch passing; pressure passing; deception passing; passing through layers; receiving under contact; first-touch control	Moves the puck with speed, accuracy and tactical purpose	High
Shooting and Scoring	Quick release; shot selection; scoring under pressure; net-front play; rebounds; tips; screens; shooting off movement	Contributes to offence through efficient scoring habits and role execution	High
Individual Attack	Creating separation; attacking defenders; offensive reads; puck protection; playmaking; net drives; zone-entry decisions	Creates or supports offensive advantages within the team structure	High
Individual Defence	Gap control; angling; body contact; defensive reads; stick detail; net-front defence; shot lanes; battle habits	Defends reliably against higher-level opponents	High
Position-Specific Skills	Forward-specific, defence-specific and goaltender-specific habits; role details; special situations	Understands and executes positional responsibilities at a higher standard	High
Team Structure	Breakouts; regrouping; forecheck; neutral-zone structure; defensive-zone coverage; offensive-zone principles; transition game	Executes the team game model with discipline and consistency	High
Special Teams	Power play; penalty kill; face-offs; 6v5; 5v6; situational awareness; role execution	Understands and performs in special-team and game-management situations	High
Game Management	Score/time awareness; momentum control; line changes; puck management; risk assessment; discipline	Makes mature decisions based on the game situation	High
Physical Development	Strength; power; speed; conditioning; mobility; recovery; nutrition habits; injury prevention	Prepares physically for senior, national team and international environments	High



Development Area	Core Skills	Expected Outcome	Priority
Mental and Professional Habits	Preparation; accountability; role acceptance; leadership; emotional control; video learning; team standards	Behaves like a performance athlete and accepts responsibility within the team	Essential